Report card comments for students with special needs

Build each comment in four parts: **something going well**, **what the student is working on now**, **what is helping**, and **the next step** (plus a home idea if you have room). Describe what the student does, not a diagnosis or plan; IEP goal progress goes in the IEP progress report. Swap [Name] and "their" for the student's name and pronoun, and keep only what is true of this student.

What's going well

Keeps trying

- [Name] keeps trying when work is hard and is proud of each step forward.
- [Name] comes to school ready to learn and works steadily through each task.

Kind to others

- [Name] is a kind friend who notices when others need help.
- [Name] greets classmates warmly and is a friendly part of our class.

Enjoys stories and books

- [Name] loves listening to stories and joins in with familiar lines.
- [Name] has grown in confidence as a reader this quarter.

Hands-on math

- [Name] enjoys hands-on math and uses objects to work out problems.
- [Name] counts carefully and checks their answers.

Art and building

- [Name] brings real imagination to art and building activities.
- [Name] shows great care and detail in their drawings.

Follows routines

- [Name] follows our classroom routines well and knows what comes next.
- [Name] settles quickly at the start of the day and gets ready to learn.

Communicates needs

- [Name] communicates their needs clearly, using words, signs or pictures.
- [Name] asks good questions when something is new.

Curious and interested

- [Name] is curious about how things work and loves to explore.
- [Name] loves sharing facts about their favorite topics with the class.

Music and PE

- [Name] joins in with real enthusiasm in music and PE.
- [Name] keeps a steady beat in music and enjoys learning new songs.

Helpful in class

- [Name] takes good care of their things and helps keep our classroom tidy.
- [Name] notices what needs doing and offers to help.

Sense of humor

- [Name] has a great sense of humor that brightens our class.
- [Name] brings energy and good humor to our class discussions.

Uses what helps

- [Name] uses the tools that help their learning without needing a reminder.
- [Name] tells an adult when their body needs a break, which is a real skill.

What they are working on

Reading: sounding out words

- **NOW** [Name] is working on reading longer words by breaking them into parts.
- **HELPS** Daily practice in a small group, with books matched to their reading, is helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to read new words in a story with fewer stops to sound them out.
- **HOME** At home, you could read together for ten minutes a day and let [Name] choose the book.

Reading: understanding the story

- **NOW** [Name] is working on retelling what happened in a story in the right order.
- **HELPS** Talking about the pictures before reading is helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to explain why a character did something, using a clue from the story.
- **HOME** At home, you could ask [Name] what happened in a story you read together, then ask why.

Writing: getting ideas down

- **NOW** [Name] is working on getting ideas onto paper and writing a few sentences in a row.
- **HELPS** Saying the sentence out loud before writing it is helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to write a short paragraph with a beginning, a middle and an end.
- **HOME** At home, you could let [Name] tell you a story and write one sentence of it down together.

Spelling and phonics

- **NOW** [Name] is working on spelling words with common patterns, such as -ing and -ed.
- **HELPS** A short daily practice with the week's pattern is helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to use these patterns in their own writing as well as in spelling practice.
- **HOME** At home, you could play a quick game of spotting this week's spelling pattern on signs and packets.

Handwriting

- **NOW** [Name] is working on forming letters the right size and keeping them on the line.
- **HELPS** A pencil grip and paper with clear lines are helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to write a whole sentence with letters that sit on the line.
- **HOME** At home, you could try activities that build hand strength, such as playdough, drawing or using tongs.

Math: number facts

- **NOW** [Name] is working on adding and subtracting within 20.
- **HELPS** Using counters and a number line is helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to recall more addition facts quickly.
- **HOME** At home, you could play quick number games with dice or playing cards.

Math: word problems

- **NOW** [Name] is working on understanding what a word problem is asking.
- **HELPS** Drawing the problem before solving it is helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to choose the right operation for a one-step word problem independently.
- **HOME** At home, you could turn everyday moments into small problems, such as sharing snacks or counting change.

Staying with a task

- **NOW** [Name] is working on staying with a task for longer before taking a break.
- **HELPS** A visual timer and short planned breaks are helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to work for ten minutes at a time before a planned break.
- **HOME** At home, you could use a timer for homework or chores, with a short break when it rings.

Getting organized

- **NOW** [Name] is working on following a checklist to get ready for each lesson.
- **HELPS** A picture checklist on their desk is helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to use the checklist with fewer reminders.
- **HOME** At home, you could use a simple checklist for the morning routine.

Sharing ideas aloud

- **NOW** [Name] is working on sharing ideas in a small group, using a sentence starter.
- **HELPS** Time to think before answering, and talking to a partner first, are helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to share an idea with the whole class.
- **HOME** At home, you could give [Name] time to answer, and ask about the best part of the day.

Asking for help

- **NOW** [Name] is working on asking for help when their work gets tricky.
- **HELPS** A help card on their desk is helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to try one step independently first, then ask for help.
- **HOME** At home, you could praise [Name] for asking when something is hard.

Managing big feelings

- **NOW** [Name] is working on using a calming strategy, such as slow breaths, when upset.
- **HELPS** A calm corner and a plan [Name] helped to choose are helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to use a calming strategy at the first sign of feeling upset.
- **HOME** At home, you could practice the same calming strategy together when things are calm.

Changes in routine

- **NOW** [Name] is working on moving from one activity to the next.
- **HELPS** A visual schedule and a warning before each change are helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to move between activities with one reminder.
- **HOME** At home, you could talk through the next day's plan the evening before.

Taking turns and sharing

- **NOW** [Name] is working on taking turns and sharing in group activities.
- **HELPS** Practicing in a small group with clear roles is helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to join in with a new group at recess.
- **HOME** At home, you could play turn-taking games, such as board games, together.

Starting work independently

- **NOW** [Name] is working on starting tasks independently after the instructions.
- **HELPS** Breaking instructions into steps, with the first step done together, is helping.
- **NEXT** Next quarter, the goal is for [Name] to start a task using a written or picture list of steps.
- **HOME** At home, you could give [Name] small jobs to finish without help.

40 short comments

1. [Name] keeps trying when work is hard and is proud of each step.
2. [Name] comes to school ready to learn every day.
3. [Name] is a kind friend who notices when others need help.
4. [Name] has grown in confidence as a reader this quarter.
5. [Name] enjoys stories and joins in with their favorite parts.
6. [Name] uses objects well to work out math problems.
7. [Name] brings real imagination to art and building.
8. [Name] follows our classroom routines and knows what comes next.
9. [Name] communicates their needs clearly with words, signs or pictures.
10. [Name] asks for help when stuck, which is a real skill.
11. [Name] uses a calming strategy when upset, with a reminder.
12. [Name] moves between activities more calmly with a visual schedule.
13. [Name] takes turns well in small group games.
14. [Name] starts tasks independently when the steps are broken down.
15. [Name] is reading longer words by breaking them into parts.
16. [Name] can retell the main events of a story in order.
17. [Name] is writing a few sentences in a row with a sentence starter.
18. [Name] is spelling more words with this quarter's patterns.
19. [Name] is forming letters more neatly and on the line.
20. [Name] is adding and subtracting within 20 with counters.
21. [Name] is learning to draw a word problem before solving it.
22. [Name] stays with a task for longer before taking a break.
23. [Name] uses their checklist to get ready for each lesson.
24. [Name] shares ideas in a small group with a sentence starter.
25. [Name] has made steady progress in reading this quarter.
26. [Name] has made steady progress in writing this quarter.
27. [Name] has made steady progress in math this quarter.
28. [Name] has grown in independence this quarter.
29. [Name] has made real gains in confidence this quarter.
30. [Name] has worked hard on their goals and it shows.
31. [Name] is proud of their progress, and so am I.
32. [Name] joins in with real enthusiasm in music and PE.
33. [Name] is curious about how things work and loves to explore.
34. [Name] has a great sense of humor that brightens our class.
35. Next, [Name] is working on reading with fewer stops.
36. Next, [Name] is working on writing a short paragraph.
37. Next, [Name] is working on recalling addition facts quickly.
38. Next, [Name] is working on asking for help after one try.
39. Next, [Name] is working on sharing an idea with the whole class.
40. Next, [Name] is working on starting tasks from a list of steps.

Phrases to avoid, rewritten

Instead of	Write
Ava has ADHD and can't sit still.	[Name] is working on staying with a task for longer. A visual timer and short planned breaks are helping.
Ava is autistic and struggles with change.	[Name] is working on moving from one activity to the next. A visual schedule and a warning before each change are helping.
Ava is dyslexic so reading is very hard for her.	[Name] is working on reading longer words by breaking them into parts, with daily practice in a small group.
Ava is a special needs student.	[Name] keeps trying when work is hard and is proud of each step forward.
Ava is very low and far behind the class.	[Name] can now read most short words on sight, and is working on longer words next.
Ava is a slow learner.	[Name] learns best with short steps and plenty of practice, and is making steady progress in reading.
Ava is low functioning.	[Name] communicates needs using pictures and is working on using two-word phrases.
Ava suffers from anxiety.	[Name] is learning to use a calming strategy, such as slow breaths, when worried, and a quiet space is helping.
Ava is wheelchair-bound but joins in.	[Name] joins in with real enthusiasm in music and PE.
Ava can't write a sentence.	[Name] is writing single words and short phrases, and is working on writing a whole sentence with a sentence starter.
Ava refuses to do her work.	[Name] is working on starting tasks when the steps are broken down, with the first step done together.
Ava has meltdowns when upset.	[Name] is learning to use a calming strategy at the first sign of feeling upset, and a calm corner is helping.
Ava has made great progress despite her disability.	[Name] has made steady progress in reading this quarter and can now retell a story in order.
Ava is an inspiration to us all.	[Name] keeps trying when work is hard, and is proud of each new word read.
Ava is meeting her IEP goals.	[Name] can now add within 10 using counters, and is working on adding within 20 next.
Ava sees the speech therapist twice a week.	[Name] is sharing ideas in a small group, using a sentence starter.
Ava needs her aide for everything.	[Name] is working on starting tasks independently, and a picture list of steps is helping.
Ava is in her own world.	[Name] is working on joining in with group activities, and practicing in a small group with clear roles is helping.
Ava is such a sweet girl.	[Name] greets classmates warmly and is a kind friend who notices when others need help.
Ava is lazy and unmotivated.	[Name] works best in short bursts, and a checklist with small steps is helping.
Ava does not try in math.	[Name] is learning to work out what a word problem is asking, and drawing the problem first is helping.
Ava is behind her peers in reading.	[Name] is reading short books with growing confidence, and is working on longer words next.

146 lines. Free from polytheseus.com/teacher-skills/guides/report-card-comments-for-special-needs-students, where a free builder puts them together and checks the wording. Drafted with AI help: read every line against what you know of the student and your school's report rules before you use it.